mujahideen factions contributed to the exodus of foreign fighters, who had no desire to be party to Muslim-on-Muslim violence. Osama bin Laden decamped to Sudan where he established al-Qaeda's headquarters, though he continued to support militants in Afghanistan and Pakistan.[12] The Taliban movement had not yet activated when bin Laden left Afghanistan, hence he had no existing ties with its leadership when he returned in 1996. By this time the Taliban had already been fighting for almost two years against the Northern Alliance and various warlords, but had yet to conquer the capital city of Kabul. Osama initially found lodging in Jalalabad with one of the mujahideen factions, which was not a major contender for national power in Afghanistan. Yet the Taliban was clearly in the ascendancy, and after it took control of Jalalabad and then Kabul in September 1996 bin Laden sought to cement his ties with the movement. He was increasing his anti-American rhetoric by this time, and in March 1997 Taliban leader Mullah Mohammad Omar 'invited' bin Laden to relocate to Kandahar. This was done under the auspices of ensuring his security, but was more likely a means of keeping bin Laden close and under control.[13]

Following the Taliban's rise to power, it allowed numerous other jihadi outfits to establish training camps in Afghanistan as well. Many of the foreigners training in Afghanistan during late-1990s were rigid Salafis for whom Deobandi Islam was anathema and they looked upon their Taliban hosts with disdain. A split existed within the Salafi-jihadi movement based in Afghanistan at the time between doctrinaire Salafi ideologues unprepared to make theological compromises and pragmatists ready to overlook doctrinal differences in the interests of furthering the jihad.[14] Al-Qaeda's leadership was and remains in the pragmatists' camp. Although al-Qaeda's senior leadership was willing to overlook doctrinal disputes, relations with the Taliban were seriously strained owing to bin Laden's preoccupation with jihad against America. International pressure and sanctions imposed on the Taliban led some of its leaders to argue for expelling bin Laden, or possibly handing him over to the Saudis.[15] While tensions remained through the end of the decade, many al-Qaeda-trained militants fought alongside the Taliban against the Northern Alliance and bin Laden's organization also contributed its own elite unit known as the 055 Brigade.